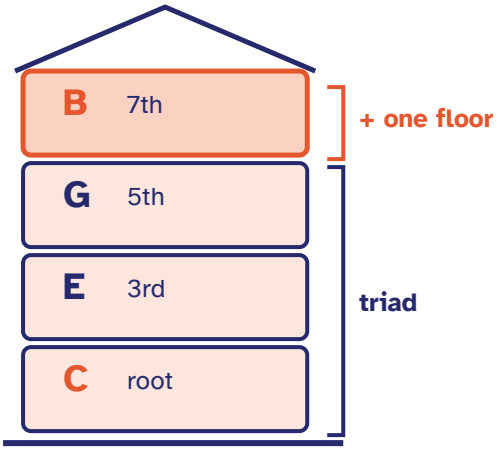
PART IV · HARMONY · 5

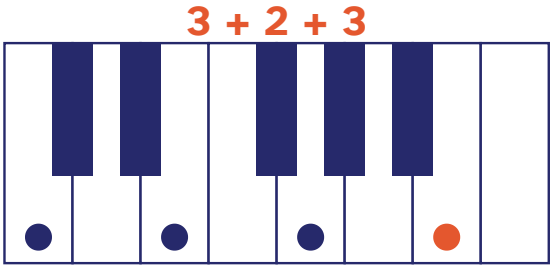
Seventh chords

Add one more floor to a triad and the chord changes colour: dreamy, bluesy, spooky. Same rule as before: skip one note, stack the next. The new note is the **7th**.

THE SECRET
One more floor on the snowman and the chord changes colour.

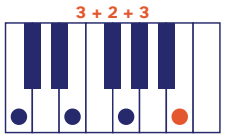


1. Build the triad: **C E G**.
2. Skip one, add the next: **B**.
3. Count the keys between: **3 + 2 + 3**. That is **Cmaj7**.



Five flavours, all on C

Cmaj7

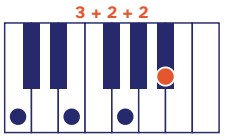


C E G B

dreamy

bossa nova, film

C7

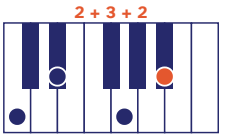


C E G B♭

bluesy

the blues

Cm7

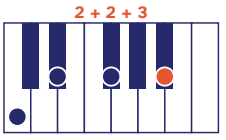


C E♭ G B♭

mellow

soul, jazz ballads

Cø7

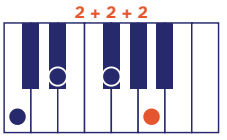


C E♭ G♭ B♭

searching

Bø7 is ii in A minor

C°7
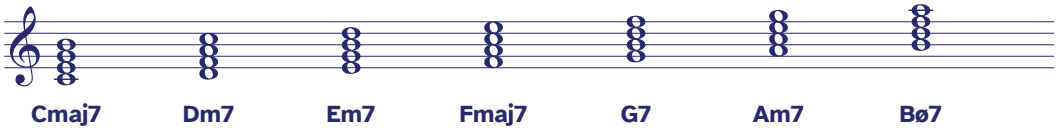


C E♭ G♭ B𝄫 (= A)

spooky

old film villains

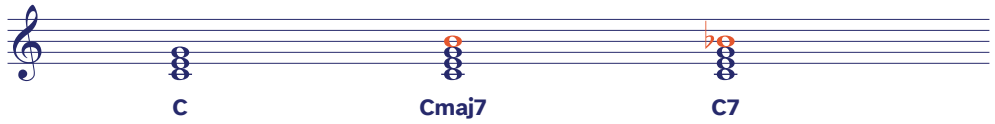
How the names work: major triad + major 7th = **maj7** · major triad + minor 7th = **7** · minor triad + minor 7th = **m7** · diminished triad + minor 7th = **ø7** · diminished triad + diminished 7th = **°7**. Also written: CM7 or CΔ = Cmaj7, C–7 = Cm7, Cm7♭5 = Cø7, Cdim7 = C°7.

A seventh on every floor of C major

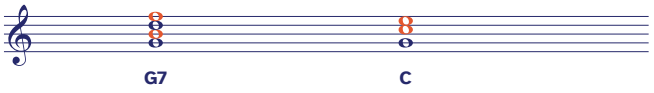


Only white keys. G7 is the one with the strongest pull home.

PART IV · HARMONY · 5 · CONTINUED



One note decides: B makes Cmaj7, B♭ makes C7. Everything below stays the same.



Why G7 pulls home: its B wants to rise to **C** and its F wants to fall to **E**. Two small steps, and you are home in C.

Spot the difference

EXAMPLE 1

Which seventh is it? G B D F



1. **Count the keys between:** G to B is 3, B to D is 2, D to F is 2.
2. **3 + 2 + 2** is the bluesy one.
3. **The root is G:** G7.

G B D F is **G7**, the chord that pulls hardest back to C.

GAME

Which seventh?

1	2	3
G B D F	C E G B	D F A C

A triad with one more floor. Name each chord.

Answer: 1 G7 (dominant 7th) · 2 Cmaj7 · 3 Dm7.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



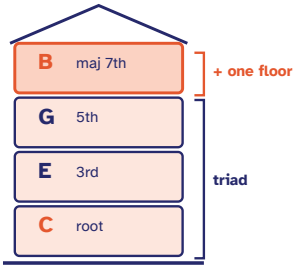
Play G7, then C.

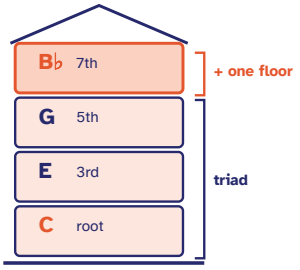
G B D F, hold it, then C E G. The F in G7 leans on E; the B leans up to C. That lean is the pull home.

PART IV · HARMONY · 5 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 2

Build Cmaj7, then C7





1. **Start with C major:** C E G.
2. **Add B**, one key below the top C: Cmaj7, dreamy.
3. **Lower it to B♭:** C7, the bluesy one that wants to move.

One key decides it: **B** is Cmaj7, **B♭** is C7.

HOW TO

Hear the four sevenths

1. **Play C7, Cmaj7, Cm7 and Cm7♭5** slowly, one after another.
2. **Name the feeling** of each: bluesy, dreamy, soft, uneasy.
3. **Then play one** without looking and guess which it is.

YOU KNOW THIS

The blues, with sevenths

I C7	I C7	I C7	I C7
IV F7	IV F7	I C7	I C7
V G7	IV F7	I C7	V G7

Swap the triads for **7th chords** and the twelve-bar chart (p. 93) turns into the real blues: the 7th is the blue note.

Try it. Play the chart with plain C, F and G first (p. 93), then add the red 7ths: B♭, E♭ and F.

THINK OF IT A triad is plain toast; the 7th is the topping: same bread, new taste.

TRAP

- × Writing C7 when you mean Cmaj7: "7" alone means the bluesy one, with B♭.
- × Stacking the 7th from the wrong note: count a 7th up from the root, not from the 5th.

SEE ALSO
Four kinds of triad p. 89 · Chords in a key p. 92

PRACTISE IT
Workbook Harmony 5 · Online: Library › Chords